

Doctrinal Statement of the Kerygma Network of Churches

Diverse in Detail, United in Devotion

Preamble: Scripture indicates that some teachings and practices are more important than others, and also indicates that differences of opinion among Christians do not need to lead to strife. The brevity of the following doctrinal statement does not aim to prevent discussion of difficult or controversial topics, but to allow for partnership even where there are differences of nuance and emphasis. Believers should be doctrine-loving but not doctrinaire, holding onto their opinions loosely, and onto their savior tightly. Above all, enthusiasm for the gospel must outpace enthusiasm for any denominational distinctives.

Doctrine of God: God is the one and only true God. He is absolutely holy, devoid of anything wrong and full of all goodness. He is all-knowing and all-powerful, and he always acts in a manner consistent with his character. He is eternal, existing always as three in one: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit. He is the maker of, yet transcendent over, all things; he is even the creator of Satan and all evil beings, yet is not the author of sin. God is love and light, severity and mercy. Full comprehension of his ways is beyond the capacity of humanity, yet he chooses to reveal himself in a general way through his creation and in a personal way in the hearts of those he calls to himself. A lover of the lowly, he loves to be approached by the humble and the broken. Rightly incensed at sin, he pours out grace on those who call on his name in truth. The central storyline of Scripture is this: God's glory is being displayed in his redemption of his people in Christ.

Doctrine of Humanity: God created all that exists, yet he fashioned humanity with particular intentionality. Humanity unites physical and spiritual elements. Humanity includes exactly two genders, male and female, though various factors (physical, cultural, and other) can create hardships in a person's experience of gender and sexuality. Marriage is for one man and one woman, and it is within marriage that sexual love is to be shown. Not everyone is called to marriage, and singleness is just as blessed as marriage. Men and women are equal in value, and both bring unique blessings to the world. Men and women of every race are also equal in value, and cultural diversity highlights God's creativity. In an American context it needs to be said that racial prejudice has been a grave problem, particularly as directed against Black and Native individuals, communities, and cultures. The civil responsibilities of government and the spiritual responsibilities of the Church operate in generally different spheres of life.

Doctrine of Salvation: Since Adam chose to disobey God, humans have universally broken God's law, dishonored his name, and polluted themselves with sin. Only Jesus Christ has fully carried out God's will. It is appropriate that God judges sinners. Yet he is so very merciful that he provides salvation in Christ: on the cross Jesus substituted himself, the righteous for the unrighteous; and by his resurrection Jesus displayed God's vindication of everyone of all ages and races who are in him. Faith in Christ, whose finished work is both necessary and sufficient, is what saves—not any intrinsic goodness in people or any good works that they do by their own power. Believers can and must show their faith by good works, which are the Spirit's fruit. Believers are adopted by God the Father, shepherded by God the Son, and indwelt by God the Spirit. To guide his people, God has given them the Holy Scriptures, which are true in their teachings, and which provide all the information needed for right living; these inspired Scriptures are those recognized in mainstream Judaism together with the twenty-seven books noted by Athanasius. God's global people are constituted as the universal Church. Ideally, they form local churches. The local church gathers primarily to worship God corporate and to nourish, encourage, and educate believers; these believers then scatter to evangelize the lost, edify one another, and bless society as they continue in the individual worship of God. The good news of salvation must and will go out to all the earth. In this present life God's children continue to suffer (sometimes even giving their lives) and to sin (sometimes grievously), and the timing of the world's end is known only to God. But at the right time Jesus will return physically to the earth, wiping away every tear and taking away all sin. God will reign forever, with his people joyously serving him.